BLANC LABS

Blanc Labs:

The Growth Frontier

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Background

Blanc Labs is a Toronto-based technology scale-up, established in 2013, that specializes in delivering cutting-edge digital and AI solutions to financial services and other industries across the Americas. Over the years, Blanc Labs has become a trusted advisor and execution partner to major banks and lenders, leveraging its expertise in AI, automation, and digital transformation to increase revenue, streamline workflows, reduce costs, and enhance the customer experience.

Having established a strong foothold in the Canadian market, Blanc Labs leadership is now planning expansion into the US. With thousands of lenders ranging from national banks to regional credit unions to non-bank mortgage originators, it is an industry increasingly hungry for automation and AI-driven efficiency gains. AI adoption is accelerating: STRATMOR reports AI and ML usage rose from 15% of lenders in 2023 to 38% in 2024. As of early 2026, HousingWire Research reports two-thirds of lenders are using or testing AI.

However, expanding into the US market presents distinct challenges. The regulatory environment differs significantly from Canada, with **overlapping federal and state regulations that vary by jurisdiction**. The competitive landscape is crowded with both established players and well-funded fintechs. Customer expectations, sales cycles, and partnership dynamics vary from what Blanc Labs has encountered domestically.

This raises a critical question**: Given the US lending market, regulatory requirements and lender technology ecosystems, how can Blanc Labs' Intelligent Lead Engagement platform enter and gain traction in the US market?**

The quality of your research and analysis will be the primary basis for evaluation. Blanc Labs values rigorous, source-backed insights over polished recommendations built on weak foundations.

US Lending Landscape

The US mortgage market has recovered from its 2023 trough of $1.5-1.7 trillion, down over 60% from the 2021 peak of $4.4 trillion. Single-family origination volumes reached $2.0 trillion in 2025, with the Mortgage Bankers Association projecting growth to $2.2 trillion in 2026. Purchase originations are forecast at $1.46 trillion with refinance originations at $737 billion for 2026.

According to Inside Mortgage Finance, **non-bank lenders control 65.2% of mortgage originations**, up from 50.8% in 2023 and roughly 39% in 2009.

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Top 10 US Mortgage Lenders (2024 HMDA Data):

Market structure matters for GTM. The Top 10 lenders illustrate the split between banks and non-banks, where scale sits, and which segments are likely to have faster buying cycles and higher appetite for point solutions versus broader platform plays.

Rank	Lender	2024 Volume	Loans	Type
1	United Wholesale Mortgage	$139.7B	366,078	Non-Bank
2	Rocket Mortgage	$97.6B	361,071	Non-Bank
3	JPMorgan Chase	$50.7B	80,744	Bank
4	CrossCountry Mortgage	$39.4B	101,894	Non-Bank
5	Wells Fargo Bank	$38.4B	37,240	Bank
6	U.S. Bank	$30.0B	74,512	Bank
7	Bank of America	$29.9B	83,165	Bank
8	Guaranteed Rate	$24.7B	62,820	Non-Bank
9	DHI Mortgage	$24.0B	70,673	Non-Bank
10	LoanDepot	$23.8B	79,418	Non-Bank

Source: HousingWire/iEmergent analysis of 2024 HMDA data (April 2025)

For this case, teams should treat lender rankings as a go-to-market input, not a background statistic. Your analysis should use the Top 10 list to draw implications for segmentation and targeting, including how bank vs non-bank models affect software buying cycles, integration burden, compliance posture, and appetite for point solutions. You **must** also **propose an initial target list**: select **5 lenders** from the

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Top 10 and **5 additional lenders** outside the Top 10 that you believe are more likely early customers or strategically valuable targets, and justify your choices with clear criteria and evidence.

Regulatory Environment

The US regulatory landscape differs significantly from Canada, with overlapping federal and state requirements. Federal bodies such as the CFPB (Consumer Financial Protection Bureau) and FTC (Federal Trade Commission) shape how lenders operate, communicate with consumers, and deploy technology. State-level requirements add further complexity, with jurisdictions taking distinct approaches to consumer privacy, marketing practices, and technology use.

Regulatory Considerations for AI-Powered Outreach

Deploying AI-driven lead engagement in the US involves specific requirements for automated communications and marketing practices. Regulations such as the Telephone Consumer Protection Act (TCPA) govern automated calls and texts and impose requirements related to consent, contact governance, and do-not-call compliance. State laws and emerging AI-related requirements may introduce additional constraints, including disclosure expectations and stricter requirements. Your analysis must identify the full set of regulatory and compliance requirements Blanc Labs must meet to deploy AI Lead Engagement agents in the US mortgage lending space. For each requirement, explain any key implications on product design, data handling, customer communications (email, SMS, voice), deployment approach, or go-to-market timing.

Required Outputs

- Compliance checklist: requirement, what it affects, evidence a lender will expect
- Consent and contact-governance flow: opt-in capture, opt-out, suppression lists, escalation to human, monitoring and auditability
- Lender readiness: top compliance and vendor risk questions and how Blanc Labs should answer them

Lender Technology Stack

US lenders operate with complex, interconnected technology ecosystems. Your analysis should map the value chain, identify where your wedge use case (i.e. new purchase, refinancing, reverse mortgage) fits, and highlight where Blanc Labs should integrate versus where it would displace existing tools.

Key technology categories to research:

- **Loan Origination Systems (LOS):** The core platforms lenders use to process applications (e.g., Encompass, Black Knight, Byte)
- **Point of Sale (POS) Systems:** Digital application portals for borrowers, brokers and loan officers
- **CRM Platforms:** Both general-purpose (Salesforce, HubSpot) and lending-specific (Total Expert, Surefire, Velocify, Jungo)

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- **Document and Verification Providers:** Income verification, asset verification, fraud detection
- **Servicing Platforms:** Post-close loan management systems
- **Marketing Automation:** Lead nurturing, drip campaigns, borrower engagement tools

Your competitive analysis should consider not only direct competitors, but also LOS, POS, and CRM vendors extending into AI-powered engagement and marketing automation, plus point solutions that overlap with lead capture, qualification, and outreach governance.

Standard Industry Integrations

US mortgage lenders also rely on shared industry utilities and data standards. Examples include automated underwriting systems such as Fannie Mae Desktop Underwriter (DU) and Freddie Mac Loan Product Advisor (LPA), and data standards such as MISMO. These are examples, not universal requirements. Teams must determine which standards and utilities are required for their chosen ICP and use case, and which are optional.

Your analysis should map the typical technology integrations required to deploy an AI Lead Engagement platform within a US mortgage lending business. Identify which systems Blanc Labs would need to integrate with, which integrations are required versus nice-to-have, and how integration requirements affect implementation timelines and partnership strategy.

Required Outputs

- **Stack map:** end-to-end lender workflow
- **Standards and utilities checklist:** which standards or utilities apply (e.g., DU, LPA, MISMO), why they matter for your ICP and use case, and what data or artifacts are involved
- **Core system integration checklist:** the 5-10 most relevant systems to connect to, why each is needed, what data is exchanged
- **Build or partner:** high-level perspective whether to build directly or use an existing partner/connector, and name specific partners where possible
- **Lender readiness:** top technical and security questions lenders will ask during vendor review and how Blanc Labs should answer them

What Lenders Want

Lenders are looking for solutions (leveraging AI and GenAI) that improve efficiency, unlock new revenue opportunities, and enhance the borrower experience, all while minimizing risk and ensuring compliance with their evolving regulatory obligations.

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Blanc Labs Platform

Blanc Labs has developed several platforms in the Canadian market, each with configured use cases for lending. For this case, you will focus on evaluating the Intelligent Lead Engagement platform for the US market potential and recommend a specific wedge use case (i.e., new purchase, refinancing, reverse mortgage) to prioritize for market entry.

Intelligent Lead Engagement Platform

What It Does:

The platform triggers outreach across multiple channels (AI voice, chat and potentially video), runs conversational AI to educate and screen clients, captures structured qualification details, books meetings, drafts communications, coordinates follow-ups, and hands off to human advisors or agents for approval and completion. It is designed to improve conversion and retention outcomes while reducing manual outreach and administrative workload.

Core Capabilities:

- Existing customers: Trigger-based monitoring (anniversaries, lifecycle events, market conditions) to identify new cross or upsell (e.g. refinancing mortgage)
- New Leads: educating, qualifying and handing off incoming new leads
- Multi-channel outreach (AI voice, AI chat, AI video)
- Conversational AI for screening, qualification, and scenario building
- Appointment booking and structured handoff to human advisors
- Follow-up automation and engagement tracking

Configured Lending Use Case Examples:

Supports borrower and customer engagement workflows across forward mortgages, refinance and reverse mortgages by triggering outreach, running chat and voice conversations to educate and screen clients, capturing structured qualification details, booking meetings, drafting communications, coordinating follow-ups, and handing off to human advisors or servicing agents for approval and completion.

Value Proposition:

Increases conversion and retention with faster, more consistent engagement, while reducing manual outreach and administrative workload through automated follow-ups, structured intake, and controlled human handoffs.

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The Deliverables

Your team will deliver a comprehensive go-to-market strategy for Blanc Labs' US market entry. This requires:

1. Market, Ecosystem, and Competitive Analysis

General industry research

- Core systems lenders use across the loan lifecycle
- Dominant vendors in each category
- Gaps, pain points, opportunities
- Vendors expanding into AI/automation

Market Opportunity Assessment:

- Size of the addressable market for US Lending (Identify TAM, SAM and SOM)
- Current adoption of similar solutions (including AI Voice and Text Agents, both horizontal ones and mortgage-specialized ones)
- Pain points this platform addresses
- Buyer personas and decision-makers

Regulatory Considerations:

- See the Regulatory Considerations for AI-Powered Outreach section for details on required outputs

Competitive Landscape:

- Direct competitors offering similar capabilities with focus on GenAI lead engagement solutions
- Indirect competitors and substitutes
- Competitive differentiation opportunities for Blanc Labs
- Barriers to entry and competitive moats

Parallel Industry Opportunities:

- Adjacent markets where this platform could be applied (e.g., insurance)
- Potential for cross-industry positioning

2. Target Lender Identification

Using the Top 10 lenders provided in this brief and your own research, identify your recommended target customers:

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From the Top 10:

- Select 5 lenders from the Top 10 list that Blanc Labs should prioritize as targets
- Justify your selection based on fit, buying cycle, technology appetite, or other criteria

Beyond the Top 10:

- Identify 5 additional lenders outside the Top 10 that you believe would be strong early targets
- These may be lenders with faster buying cycles, higher appetite for point solutions, specific pain points the platform addresses, or other characteristics that make them attractive first customers
- Justify why these lenders should be prioritized

3. Go-to-Market Strategy

Target Customer Segmentation:

- Which lender types to prioritize (national banks, non-bank originators, credit unions, etc.)
- Rationale for prioritization
- Key accounts to target

Positioning & Messaging:

- Value proposition tailored to US buyers
- Competitive positioning
- Key proof points and credibility builders

Integration Considerations:

- See the Standard Industry integrations section for details on required outputs

Channel Strategy:

- Direct sales vs. partnerships vs. channel sales (If partnerships are recommended, name the first partner type and 1–2 specific candidates.)
- Integration partnerships (LOS vendors, other ecosystem players)
- Industry associations and events

Pricing Considerations:

- Pricing model recommendations (per-loan, subscription, hybrid)
- Competitive pricing context

Organizational Requirements:

- US presence needs (sales, support, compliance)
- Partnership requirements
- Timeline considerations

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4. Cost to enter market

- Estimate cost to enter the US market with this solution, include items like sales, marketing, partnerships, compliance & regulatory etc.

5. Risks & Mitigation

- Identify the top risks to successful US market entry and proposed mitigation strategies.

Guidance

Market Research Package

Your deliverables will be evaluated primarily on the strength of your research. A well-supported analysis with a modest recommendation will outperform a bold recommendation with thin evidence. **This package must include:**

1. Source Documents

Provide the underlying material for every source you relied on.

- Accepted evidence formats: PDFs, report excerpts, print-to-PDF web pages, screenshots of key tables/charts, and exported tables (CSV/Excel).
- Do not cite any source unless its supporting evidence is included in your submission.
- Reputable sources include:
    - Industry databases and research providers (e.g., Statista, Euromonitor Passport, IBISWorld, Gartner)
    - Consulting and advisory firms (e.g., McKinsey, BCG, Bain, Deloitte, PwC, EY, KPMG, Accenture)
    - Regulatory and government publications
    - Academic research
    - Established trade publications
    - Company filings and investor materials
    - Credible journalism with transparent sourcing

- **Not acceptable**: blogs/unverified sites, AI-generated summaries.

2. Data Tables & Exhibits

- Market sizing calculations with source data

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- Lender technology stack mapping (core systems, dominant vendors by category, integration patterns, AI/automation expansion trends)
- Competitive landscape matrices
- Regulatory requirement summaries
- Financial assumptions where relevant

Guardrails and Scope

- You must evaluate the Intelligent Lead Engagement platform for US entry
- You may propose packaging changes, pricing, sequencing, partnerships, implementation approach, and integration strategy, as long as it leverages the Intelligent Lead Engagement platform's core capabilities
- Your GTM strategy must be specific to the US market and include: ICP, buyer map, positioning, channel strategy, scaling plan
- Do not assume full access to production borrower data during early conversations. Your pilot design must work with constrained data access and controlled environments
- You are not expected to provide legal advice. You must identify regulatory and compliance considerations and how they affect feasibility, timeline, and the sales process

Evaluation Focus Areas

Research Quality: Is your analysis grounded in credible, verifiable sources?

Market Understanding: Do you demonstrate genuine understanding of the US lending market?

Regulatory Awareness: Have you incorporated regulatory constraints into your strategy?

Technology Ecosystem Fit: Do you understand how lenders' existing technology stacks work and where Blanc Labs fits?

Strategic Thinking: Is your recommendation well-reasoned and defensible?

Practical Feasibility: Is your GTM strategy actionable?

Financial Rigor: Are your projections grounded in reasonable assumptions?

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A Glimpse Toward the Future

By tackling this challenge, you'll help Blanc Labs define its next frontier in AI innovation, forging a market entry strategy that captures significant share in the world's largest lending market.

Good luck. Blanc Labs looks forward to your bold ideas, thorough insights, and strategic thinking as we reimagine what's possible in the American market.

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